DATA MANAGEMENT PLAN

THESIS TITLE: A COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF HOW IN-HOUSE AND OUTSOURCED OPERATIONS AFFEC T A COMPANY'S RISK PROFILE

1. Purpose and Scope

We will use this Data Management Plan to guide how we collect, organise, store, analyse, protect, and dispose of data throughout our thesis project. Our approach will follow applicable Karelia University of Applied Sciences (Karelia UAS) guidance on research ethics, data protection, data management, and research integrity.

Our research data will consist primarily of questionnaire responses, cleaned datasets, analysis files, research notes, and literature and references relevant to our research questions.

2. Research Data and Collection

We will collect questionnaire responses from participants with relevant professional knowledge of in-house and outsourced operations. The questionnaire will address operating models, operational risks, strategic and business risks, governance, continuity, and make-or-buy decisions.

We will also use relevant published literature and publicly available sources to establish the theoretical and contextual basis for our analysis.

We will collect only information necessary to answer our research questions. We will avoid requesting unnecessary personal information or confidential company details. Before participants submit their responses, we will provide appropriate information about the study and how their data will be used.

3. Personal Data, Consent, and Confidentiality

Some questionnaire responses may contain information that could identify participants directly or indirectly, such as company names, job titles, or other professional details. We will minimise the collection of such information and anonymise or pseudonymise responses where appropriate.

If we collect contact information, we will store it separately from questionnaire responses and restrict access to it. We will explain the purpose of the research, voluntary participation, confidentiality arrangements, and applicable withdrawal conditions to participants before data collection.

We will confirm the appropriate lawful basis for processing personal data, consent arrangements, and participant information with our thesis supervisor in accordance with applicable data-protection requirements and Karelia UAS guidance.

We will not disclose identifiable participant information or confidential company information in our thesis without an appropriate basis and the necessary authorisation.

4. Data Storage and Security

We intend to store our research data on a personal computer protected by access controls and appropriate security measures. We will maintain organised files and secure backups to reduce the risk of data loss.

Where contact information is collected, we will keep it separate from response data and limit access to what is necessary for the research. We will not make raw research data publicly accessible or share it with unauthorised persons.

Before collecting data, we will confirm with our supervisor whether storing the data on a personal computer is acceptable or whether Karelia UAS requires us to use an approved university storage platform.

5. Data Organisation and Quality Control

We will use consistent file names and version control to distinguish original questionnaire exports, cleaned datasets, analysis files, and final outputs.

We will preserve the original questionnaire data separately from working copies. During data cleaning, we will document how we handle incomplete responses, duplicate submissions, inconsistent answers, and missing values. We will not modify responses to support a preferred conclusion.

Before analysis, we will check the completeness and consistency of the dataset, verify coding, and document any exclusions or transformations that could affect our findings. We will maintain a clear connection between the collected data, our analysis, and the conclusions presented in the thesis.

6. Data Analysis and Research Integrity

We will analyse questionnaire responses according to our research questions and planned methods. Where the sample and data quality permit, we will use descriptive statistics and comparisons between in-house and outsourced operating models. We will analyse open-text responses, if collected, using a consistent and documented approach.

We will distinguish participant responses, published evidence, our analytical interpretations, and our conclusions. We will report limitations and uncertainty honestly and will not present findings as more representative or conclusive than the available evidence supports.

We will maintain a reference record containing sufficient bibliographic information to verify our sources. Before citing a source, we will check that it supports the relevant claim.

We may use AI tools for permitted tasks such as organising information, improving writing, or assisting with analysis, subject to Karelia UAS guidance. We will verify relevant information against original sources and will not treat AI-generated output as an independent research source. As the two researchers, we will remain responsible for the accuracy, originality, interpretation, and integrity of our work.

7. Data Sharing and Reporting

We will present our findings in a way that protects participant confidentiality and avoids unnecessary disclosure of commercially sensitive information.

Where appropriate, we will report aggregated results or anonymised extracts rather than identifiable individual responses. We will not publish raw questionnaire data by default. Before sharing any research data, we will consider participant information, consent arrangements, confidentiality commitments, data-protection requirements, and our supervisor's guidance.

We will prepare and submit the thesis and supporting documentation in accordance with Karelia UAS requirements.

8. Data Retention and Disposal

Our intended approach is to retain the research data until thesis assessment is complete and then securely delete it, provided this is permitted by applicable Karelia UAS requirements, participant arrangements, and any relevant research agreement.

Before deleting the data, we will confirm whether any records must be retained for assessment, verification, or another specified institutional purpose. We will also consider identifiable information and backups containing research data when carrying out disposal.

We will confirm the applicable retention period and disposal procedure with our supervisor before data collection begins.

9. Responsibilities and Review

As the two researchers working on this group thesis, we will jointly take responsibility for implementing this plan, maintaining data quality, protecting participant information, documenting analytical decisions, and complying with applicable research ethics and data-protection requirements.

We will agree on the division of data-management tasks and ensure that both researchers understand the storage arrangements, access restrictions, data-cleaning procedures, and requirements for handling confidential information.

We will consult our thesis supervisor if we are uncertain about research permits, consent arrangements, approved storage, retention, disposal, or other institutional requirements.

We will review and update this plan if our data-collection methods, personal-data requirements, storage arrangements, or intended data sharing change materially.

Our guiding principle: We will collect only the data necessary for our research, protect it throughout the project, maintain traceability between evidence and findings, and dispose of the data in accordance with confirmed institutional and legal requirements.